

# PLURALITY & UNITY

## IN THE ESTABLISHMENT OF THE KINGDOM OF GOD

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When the brethren (ministries) at the beginning of the "Move of the Spirit" began to function in oneness and unity and in submission to one another, it was a revelation that kept the church on a firm foundation. There was no longer any tolerance for anyone, locally or universally, going off on a tangent and ministering what seemed to be right in his own eyes. A plurality of many brethren who walk in unity with one another cannot be accomplished in the flesh. I submit to you that if this principle had not been adhered to at the very beginning, the "Move of the Spirit" may have been blown to the four winds today.

We have witnessed many prominent men in the religious field who have gone astray largely because they were a law unto themselves and did not have anyone to balance them or anyone who was viewed as an equal to consult with them. Thus, they were determined to go in their own misguided direction. Proverbs 21:4 says, "Every way of man is right in his own eyes: but the Lord ponders (weighs) the hearts." While there are examples of God having anointed the one-man ministry and they have had their place in the plan of God, I believe that the emphasis in this present

day is a plurality of ministries walking in submission and ultimately fulfilling the will and plan of God. Ephesians 4:11–16 outlines the plan of God in bringing the body of Christ to maturity. This is in no way a singular effort, but rather a plurality of ministries that will result in the many-membered body of Christ coming "to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ" (v. 13). "And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, for the equipping of the saints for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ, till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ; that we should no longer be children, tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the trickery of men, in the cunning craftiness of deceitful plotting, but, speaking the truth in love, may grow up in all things into Him who is the head – Christ – from whom the whole body, joined and knit together by what every joint supplies, according to the effective working by which every part does its share, causes growth of the body for the edifying of itself in love" (NKJV).

I was reading in the booklet titled, “The Move of the Spirit of God” and I will quote a portion from it. “There have been some very prominent brethren who were mightily used of God in the beginning of the move, who have since missed the way and departed from it, but nevertheless God has moved on, building His temple and preparing that body for Christ. God is not building on men. Paul also realized that the thing that was important to God was not him, but the ministry that came down from heaven; that was abiding within him – and his yielding to that ministry. That is why he said in 1 Corinthians 9:26 & 27, *“I therefore so run, not as uncertainly, so fight I, not as one that beateth the air, but I keep my body under and bring it in to subjection lest that by any means when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.”* May we all realize today that we stand by the grace of God, and not by any merit of our own, and this that God has called us into, is a move of God’s Spirit, preparing us for the kingdom of God. God is still moving by His Holy Spirit, leading us ever on” (pp. 20 & 21).

God introduced the truth or principle of plurality early in the scriptures. In Genesis 1:26, we read, *“Then God said, ‘Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness; let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, over the birds of the air; and over the cattle, over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth’”* (NKJV). The existence of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit conferring together in the creation of man demonstrates plurality and perfect unity in the Godhead. Also, in Genesis 2:18, we see plurality in God’s plan for marriage. *“It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him an help meet for him”* (KJV). The woman (Adam’s wife) would not be inferior to him or superior to him, but rather equal with him. She would have a different office than he had; she would be a suitable help meet to him (his counterpart); she would be submissive to his headship, but not inferior or of lesser importance. She would be deserving of his love as her provider, protector and spiritual head. His love would be sacrificial, and her respect would be for him. Obviously, companionship and communication are very important aspects of the marriage relationship. Eve made a fundamental error when she took of the fruit and ate it. The scripture says nothing about discussing this decision with Adam. She did not ask his advice, but rather chose, on Satan’s prompting to act on what God had forbidden. The scripture says in Proverbs 11:14, *“Where no counsel is, the people fall: but in the multitude of counsellors there is safety”* (KJV).

It seems that when a truth is made real to you, you begin to see it in many places in the Bible. For example, the Lord chose twelve disciples who were ordinary men with different personalities, drawn from diverse backgrounds and possessing the same human weaknesses that we all have. However, the Lord saw beyond their flaws and shortcomings to what they could become through submission and obedience to the will of God. While the disciples had their disagreements, the Lord always pointed them in the direction of kingdom of God, love for each other, and unity of mind and purpose. He is doing the same today. *“These twelve Jesus sent out and commanded*

*them saying, ‘... go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. And as you go, preach, saying, the kingdom of God is at hand. Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out demons. Freely you have received, freely give’”* (Matthew 10:5–8, NKJV). Then again, in Mark 16:14–18, *“Later He appeared to the eleven as they sat at the table; and He rebuked their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they did not believe those who had seen Him after He had risen. And He said to them, ‘Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature. He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned. And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues; they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover’”* (NKJV). There is a plurality here in the disciples that Jesus used to work the works of Christ in the earth. It was not about how great or how talented they were, but rather it was about the Spirit of God working through them to accomplish what God desired to fulfill in the lives of men and women. God does not anoint the flesh, for in the flesh there is no good thing. Similarly, in Luke 10:1, 17-20, we see the following plurality put in place once again, *“After these things the Lord appointed 70 others also, and sent them two by two before His face into every city and place where He Himself was about to go”* (v.1) *“Then the seventy returned with joy, saying, ‘Lord, even the demons are subject to us in Your name’”* (v. 17). *“And He said to them, ‘I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. Behold, I give you the authority to trample on serpents and scorpions, and over all the powers of the enemy, and nothing shall by any means hurt you. Nevertheless do not rejoice in this, that the spirits are subject to you, but rather rejoice because your names are written in heaven’”* (vs. 18-20). Jesus puts everything in perspective. While these 70 that He had sent out gloried in the evidence of the authority imparted to them, Jesus said that much more important is that they had made their *“calling and election sure”* (2 Peter 1:10, KJV).

There is no room for pride, selfishness or human ambition in what God is building; the flesh will have no part in it. *“Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God”* (1 Corinthians 15:50). The hymn writer penned these prophetic words of unity in the song:

For I’m building a people of power  
And I’m making a people of praise  
That will move through this land by My Spirit  
And will glorify My precious name.

Build your church, Lord  
Make it strong, Lord  
Join our hearts, Lord, to Your Son  
Make us one, Lord, in Your body  
In the kingdom of Your Son.

In the building of the tabernacle, God instructed Moses to do everything according to the pattern that he had been divinely shown on the mountain. In other words, there was

no room for Moses to adjust or change anything. It had to be done just as God had directed and planned. This is a serious hour. Today we must build according to the pattern that God has laid down for the church. There is no place for the mind of man in it, for if we build on the theories and ideologies of man we surely build on sinking sand. But rather we are built on the rock: *“on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ Himself being the chief cornerstone”* (Ephesians 2:20, NKJV). In 2 Timothy 2:19, we read, *“The solid foundation of God stands, having this seal: ‘The Lord knows those who are His,’ and, ‘Let everyone who names the name of Christ depart from iniquity’”* (NKJV).

Let us have a look at the circumstances that Moses faced in Numbers chapter 11. The people complained because they had grown tired of the manna that they gathered daily and they remembered the fish, the cucumbers, the melons, the leeks, the onions and the garlic they had in Egypt and they hankered for these things, even though the manna was a complete food in itself. They demanded that Moses provide them with meat. *“So Moses said to the Lord, ‘Why have You afflicted your servant? And why have I not found favor in Your sight, that You have laid the burden of all these people on me? Did I conceive all these people? Did I beget them, that You should say to me, ‘carry them in Your bosom, as a guardian carries a nursing child,’ to the land which You swore to their fathers? Where am I to get meat to give to all these people? For they weep all over me saying, ‘Give us meat that we may eat.’ I am not able to bear all these people alone, because the burden is too heavy for me”* (Numbers 11:11-14, NKJV). So what was the Lord’s response to the predicament that Moses was in? It was quite simply to add a plurality of brethren to him, as we see, beginning at verse 16, *“So the Lord said to Moses, ‘Gather to Me seventy men of the elders of Israel, whom you know to be elders of the people and officers over them; bring them to the tabernacle of meeting, that they may stand there with you. Then I will come down and talk with you there. I will take of the Spirit that is upon you and will put the same upon them; and they shall bear the burden of the people with you, that you may not bear it yourself alone”* (vs. 16 & 17, NKJV).

There are many instances in scripture where there are references to elders (plural) rather than elder (singular). Let us look at a few of those. James 5:14, *“Is any among you sick? Let him call for the elders of the church, and let them pray over him...”* (NJKV). Paul and Barnabas when traveling to Lystra, Iconium and Antioch, *“appointed elders in every church, and prayed with fasting, they commended them to the Lord in whom they had believed”* (Acts 14:23, NKJV). Paul speaking to Titus says, *“For this reason I left you in Crete, that you should set in order the things that are lacking and appoint elders in every city as I commanded you...”* (Titus 1:5, NKJV).

The truth of plurality is plain in both the Old and New Testaments as revealed in the examples that have been noted here. God wants brethren to walk in unity. It is not sufficient to just have plurality of leadership in the church. There must also be unity in the Spirit among all who make

up the plurality. God has warned us against yielding to our human nature, which is too often convinced that our own way is the best and only way. *“There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death”* (Proverbs 14:12, 16:25, NKJV). Unity in the Spirit is not always easy to achieve within a plurality. Regardless of a person’s maturity in the Spirit, God has created us to need the counsel and input from others to know His mind and will regarding issues we face. *“For by wise counsel you will wage your own war, and in a multitude of counsellors there is safety”* (Proverbs 24:6, NKJV). A man at any level of the church who cannot receive the counsel of his brethren and who cannot yield to the correction given by them disqualifies himself from headship. The only way that unity can prevail among a plurality of brethren is by the Spirit of God. In the flesh there is no unity. In carnality there is only division. Romans 8:5-8 from the Phillips translation, in speaking of carnality, puts it this way, *“The carnal attitude sees no further than natural things. But the spiritual attitude reaches out after the things of the Spirit. The former attitude means, bluntly, death: the latter means life and inward peace. And this is only to be expected, for the carnal attitude is inevitably opposed to the purpose of God, and neither can nor will follow His laws for living. Men who hold this attitude cannot possibly please God.”*

Down through history in the various moves of God there has been divine revelation, even unto this present day. Our responsibility is to walk and be established in present truth. *“The secret things belong unto the Lord our God: but those things which are revealed belong unto us and to our children for ever, that we may do all the words of this law”* (Deuteronomy 29:29, KJV). The Lord has revealed much to His people over these many years. I often wonder how long it will be before He will trust us with our full inheritance. What a day it will be when the sons of God will come forth in the image and likeness of Christ, possessing His nature and His attributes. It will never happen by human effort or by the ambitions and plans of man, but rather by the transforming power of the Spirit of Christ working in our lives on a daily basis. *“Not by might nor by power, but by My Spirit, says the Lord of hosts”* (Zechariah 4:6, NKJV).

There is always consistency with God. Headship, submission and plurality are distinctive features of God’s order. We see it in marriage with husband and wife. We see it in the local church with elders and deacons. We see it in the universal church with travelling elders and travelling deacons. A church office at every level carries with it a God-given authority and the accompanying privilege of serving, but in no way does it make one person superior to another. Superior – subordinate relationships and power vested in one man or one woman are for the world, not the church. Even in a church office, a man can easily go astray if brethren who hold the same office as he does do not balance and sometimes correct him. In addition, all who hold that office must be equal. There is no room for chief elders or deacons at either the local or universal levels regardless of the time served.

The world's order must never be superimposed on the church. It will be a recipe for disaster and the undoing of that which God is building. *"For we are God's fellow workers; you are God's field, you are God's building. According to the grace of God which was given to me, as a master builder. I have laid the foundation, and another builds on it. But let each one take heed how he builds on it. For no other foundation can anyone lay than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ"* (1 Corinthians 3:9-11, NKJV). The order of God is perfect and He will give us the ability to walk in His order if we are willing and obedient and submit to the leading of the Holy Spirit.

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NC Summer Camp.....July 13-20, 2025

Pinelaw Summer Camp.....August 3-9, 2025

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